

- RAG Learning

1.2 Political Parties

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 1: UK Politics, Section A

Political parties are examined in Section A of Component 1. The spec divides the topic into four parts: what parties are and how they are funded; the three established parties; emerging and minor parties; and parties in context — which is where the evaluative marks sit. A 30-mark question here will almost always require you to connect party behaviour to the electoral system.

Political party — an organised group seeking to form government by putting up candidates and offering a programme.

Manifesto — the document setting out the policies a party pledges to enact if elected.

Mandate — the authority a governing party claims to implement the programme on which it was elected.

Old Labour (social democracy) — nationalisation, redistribution, strong trade unions, universal welfare.

New Labour (Third Way) — acceptance of the market economy combined with social investment and opportunity.

One Nation — the paternalist conservative tradition holding that the privileged owe obligations to the less fortunate.

New Right — neo-liberal economics combined with neo-conservative social policy.

Classical liberal — minimal state, negative freedom, free markets.

Modern liberal — enabling state, positive freedom, social justice.

Party systems — the number of parties with a realistic prospect of power and the pattern of competition between them.

Left wing / right wing — broadly, preference for equality and collective provision against preference for hierarchy, tradition and the market.

1. Functions and funding

Functions

Function	What it involves	How well it is performed
Representation	Aggregating diverse interests into a coherent programme	Weakened by dealignment — parties represent shrinking and less distinct social bases
Participation and mobilisation	Recruiting members, campaigning, structuring debate	Membership far below post-war levels, though with sharp surges (Labour 2015, SNP 2014)
Recruitment and selection	Selecting candidates; supplying the pool from which ministers are drawn	Effective, but narrows the political class — a growing share of MPs come from politics-adjacent careers
Policy formulation	Developing and testing policy; producing a manifesto	Increasingly shared with think tanks and special advisers
Stable government	Providing a disciplined majority capable of governing	Delivered by FPTP, though interrupted in 2010 and 2017

Membership: the long decline

Period	Combined membership of the largest parties
Early 1950s	Around 3 million (Conservatives alone claimed roughly 2.8 million in 1953)
1980s	Falling steadily across both major parties
2013	All parties combined below 1% of the electorate
Post-2014 surges	Labour passed 500,000 after 2015; the SNP grew several-fold after the independence referendum

The surges matter analytically because they cut against a simple decline narrative. They were driven by a leadership contest open to members and by a constitutional question — which

suggests people will join a party when membership visibly confers power, and will not when it does not.

Funding

Source	Detail
Membership	A small proportion of income for the largest parties; more significant for smaller ones
Donations	Conservatives draw heavily on business and individual donors; Labour historically on affiliated trade unions, now more on individual members
Short money	Public funding for opposition parties in the Commons, to support parliamentary work. Cranborne money is the Lords equivalent
Policy Development Grants	Limited public funding, distributed by the Electoral Commission, for policy development

The regulatory framework is the **Political Parties, Elections and Referendums Act 2000**, which created the Electoral Commission, required reporting of donations above a threshold, banned foreign donations and capped national campaign spending. It followed the Fifth Report of the Committee on Standards in Public Life (the Neill Report, 1998).

Why funding remains controversial

- **Loans rather than gifts (2006).** Both major parties had accepted large loans that fell outside PPERA's disclosure rules because they were not, in law, donations. The Electoral Administration Act 2006 closed the gap by requiring loans to be reported on the same basis.
- **The "cash for honours" investigation (2006–07).** A police investigation into whether peerages had been offered in return for loans concluded without charges, but the episode established the reputational problem: where a small number of large donors fund a party, the appearance of purchased access is difficult to dispel even where nothing unlawful occurred.
- **Trade union affiliation.** The Trade Union Act 2016 required new members to opt *in* to a union's political fund rather than opt out, which was expected to reduce Labour's affiliated income.

Whether this was a transparency measure or a partisan one was contested at the time.

- **Unincorporated associations.** Money routed through associations whose own donors are not disclosed remains a recognised gap in the regime.

Should parties be funded by the state?

For	Against
Reduces dependence on wealthy donors and so weakens the link between money and access	Compels citizens to fund parties whose views they reject
Levels competition between parties with different fundraising capacity	Any distribution formula — by votes, seats or members — rewards existing parties and raises the barrier to new entrants
Frees parties to develop policy rather than fundraise continuously	Severs the incentive to recruit and retain members, weakening parties' roots in society
Recurrent funding controversies damage trust in the whole system	Partial state funding already exists through Short money and policy grants
Practised widely in Europe without evident harm to party competition	Would require agreement among the parties that benefit from the present arrangement

Exam Tip: Funding questions reward specificity. Name PPERA 2000, name the Neill Report that produced it, name Short money, and note that the argument is not between "no state funding" and "state funding" but about how much more. That framing alone lifts an answer out of the generic.

2. The established parties

Conservative Party

Period	Position
Origins	Emerged from the Tory tradition; Peel's Tamworth Manifesto (1834) accepted reform in order to conserve
One Nation	Disraeli's warning of "two nations" of rich and poor; social reform to preserve cohesion. Dominant through the post-war consensus under Macmillan and Heath
New Right / Thatcherism	From 1975: privatisation, trade union reform, monetarism, tax reduction, right-to-buy, combined with social conservatism and a strong state on law and defence
Major and after	Continuity on economics; Europe became the dividing question and the source of visible division
Cameron modernisation	Acceptance of NHS spending, equal marriage, environmental commitments, alongside post-2010 austerity
Post-2016	Realignment around Brexit; a more interventionist economic offer in leave-voting seats ("levelling up") in tension with the party's low-tax tradition

Internal factions: One Nation members; free-market Thatcherites; a socially conservative and Eurosceptic right. The leadership rule — MPs narrow the field to two, members choose between them — gives the membership decisive influence and is one reason the parliamentary party and the membership can pull in different directions.

Labour Party

Period	Position
Origins	Founded 1900 out of the trade union movement and socialist societies; Clause IV (1918) committed the party to common ownership
Post-war	Attlee government: NHS, nationalisation, the welfare state

1983	Manifesto committing to widespread nationalisation, unilateral disarmament and withdrawal from the EEC; heavy defeat. Called "the longest suicide note in history" by a Labour MP
Kinnock to Smith	Expulsion of Militant; reform of internal procedures; the beginning of the move to the centre
New Labour	Clause IV rewritten in 1995; acceptance of the market economy; the Third Way — investment funded by growth, tax credits, the minimum wage, constitutional reform
2015–2019	A sharp move left under Corbyn: public ownership of utilities and rail, higher taxation, expanded state spending
Post-2020	Move back towards the centre under Starmer, with tighter internal discipline and fiscal restraint

Internal structure: the National Executive Committee, the annual Conference, affiliated trade unions and the Parliamentary Labour Party each hold a share of power. The 2014 Collins review introduced one member one vote for leadership elections, which produced an outcome in 2015 that the reform's designers had not anticipated — a useful illustration that internal rules have unintended consequences.

Liberal Democrats

Formed in 1988 from the merger of the Liberal Party and the SDP. The party contains a **classical liberal** strand (the *Orange Book* tradition, market-oriented) and a **social liberal** strand (an enabling state). Constitutional reform — proportional representation, an elected Lords, entrenched rights — is its most consistent distinctive commitment.

Coalition record 2010–15	
Secured	The AV referendum; a rising income tax personal allowance; the pupil premium; blocking of a proposed "snoopers' charter"
Conceded	Tuition fees — a signed pledge to oppose any rise, then a vote to treble the cap; the NHS reorganisation; the scale of austerity

Cost	57 seats in 2010 to 8 in 2015. The party has since recovered partially, but its 2010 position has not returned
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Policy comparison

Area	Conservative	Labour	Liberal Democrat
Economy	Lower taxation, restraint on spending, market provision	Higher public investment, greater redistribution	Market economy with substantial public investment
Welfare	Conditionality, work incentives	More generous entitlement, less conditionality	Targeted support, opposition to the harshest conditions
Constitution	Broadly content with existing arrangements	Mixed; some support for Lords reform	Proportional representation, elected Lords, federalism
Law and order	Longer sentences, expanded police powers	Emphasis on causes alongside enforcement	Civil liberties, opposition to expanded surveillance
Europe	Withdrawal completed; divergence from EU rules	Closer relationship without rejoining	Closest alignment of the three

3. Emerging and minor parties

Party	Base	Significance
SNP	Scotland; independence and social democracy	Dominant since 2015; removed a bloc of seats from two-party competition and altered Westminster arithmetic

Plaid Cymru	Wales; devolution, language, independence	Consistent minority representation; influence in the Senedd
Green Party	Environment, social justice	Substantial vote share converted into very few Westminster seats; better represented under proportional systems
UKIP / Brexit Party / Reform	Euroscepticism, immigration	The clearest case of influence without seats: 12.6% and one seat in 2015, having already forced the referendum commitment
DUP / Sinn Féin and others	Northern Ireland	A separate party system; the DUP held the balance of power under confidence and supply from 2017

Why minor parties struggle — and still matter

First-past-the-post rewards **concentrated** support and punishes **dispersed** support. The 2015 comparison is the standard illustration: UKIP took 12.6% of the vote for one seat; the SNP took 4.7% for fifty-six. Wasted-vote perceptions compound the effect, and broadcast allocation and funding follow past performance.

They matter nonetheless by **shifting the agenda**. Established parties adopt minor-party positions to stop losing votes, so influence appears in the policy of governments rather than in seat totals. UKIP is the decisive case: it never held more than two Commons seats, and it obtained a referendum on EU membership. That is a larger policy achievement than most governing parties manage in a term.

Exam Tip: The UKIP example is the single most useful illustration in this topic because it works in three different questions: the failure of minor parties under FPTP, the influence of minor parties despite that failure, and the instability of the two-party system. Learn the two numbers — 12.6% and one seat — and the outcome.

4. UK political parties in context

Is the UK still a two-party system?

Still two-party	No longer two-party
Labour and the Conservatives have alternated in office since 1945	Coalition (2010) and minority government (2017) interrupted single-party rule
2015, 2019 and 2024 all produced single-party majorities	The SNP has dominated Scotland since 2015
Combined Con+Lab seat share remains overwhelming	Combined Con+Lab vote share fell from nearly 97% in 1951 to 57% in 2024
Only those two parties can realistically form a government	Devolved legislatures sustain genuine multi-party politics; Northern Ireland has an entirely separate system

The resolution worth writing: the UK now has **multi-party competition at the level of votes and two-party dominance at the level of seats**, and the gap between them is produced by the electoral system. That is a more precise answer than choosing one label, and it connects the topic to electoral systems, which is where the higher marks are.

Other party systems for comparison

- **Dominant-party system** — one party wins repeatedly although others compete freely. Scotland since 2015 is a reasonable description.
- **Multi-party system** — several parties hold power in coalition. The Senedd and the Scottish Parliament.
- **Two-and-a-half party system** — two large parties plus a third whose support matters at the margin. A common description of the UK between the 1970s and 2010.

Factors affecting party success

- **Governing competence** — the dominant valence consideration. Reputations lost through visible failure (the ERM crisis in 1992, the 2022 mini-budget) do not recover quickly.

- **Leadership** — more consequential since partisan dealignment, as a shortcut for judging a party.
- **Unity** — visible division signals inability to govern; the Conservatives in the 1990s and Labour after 2015.
- **Party funding and organisation** — converts support into votes where it counts, through targeting and ground campaigns.
- **The media** — agenda-setting determines the ground on which a campaign is fought.
- **The electoral system** — efficient distribution matters more than raw vote share.

Have the parties converged?

Convergence was real between roughly 1994 and 2008: Labour accepted the market economy and the Conservatives accepted NHS spending, the minimum wage and equalities legislation, with both competing for the median voter as Downsian analysis predicts under FPTP. Divergence returned after 2015 over austerity, the size of the state, public ownership and Brexit — which cut across the conventional left–right axis entirely.

The deeper point is that the *degree* of convergence is itself determined by the electoral system and the distribution of opinion. FPTP rewards capturing the centre, so convergence is the default when opinion is unimodal, and divergence appears when a crisis or new cleavage splits the electorate in a way the centre cannot contain. Both parties therefore converge and diverge for the same underlying reason — the pursuit of a winning coalition.

Exam Tip: For "To what extent have UK parties converged?", do not treat it as yes or no. Date the convergence (roughly 1994–2008), date the divergence (post-2015), and explain the mechanism. That converts a descriptive answer into an analytical one and gives you an AO3 judgement that follows from the analysis rather than being asserted at the end.

Quick recall

- Functions: representation, participation, recruitment, policy formulation, stable government
- PPERA 2000 (from the Neill Report) created the Electoral Commission; the 2006 Act closed the loans gap; Short money is existing partial state funding

- Conservative: One Nation → New Right → modernisation → post-2016 realignment
- Labour: Clause IV 1918 → 1983 defeat → rewritten 1995 → Third Way → 2015 left turn → post-2020 return to the centre
- Lib Dems: Orange Book and social liberal strands; coalition cost 57 seats to 8
- 2015: UKIP 12.6% = 1 seat; SNP 4.7% = 56 seats — concentration beats size under FPTP
- UKIP: never more than two seats, and it obtained the referendum — influence without representation
- Two-party in seats, multi-party in votes — the gap is made by the electoral system
- Convergence 1994–2008, divergence post-2015; both driven by the search for a winning coalition